

Confederate detachments. The most serious of the engagements came at Saylers Creek on April 6, when three Union corps cut off a quarter of Lee's army, capturing some 6,000 men.

Their strength sapped by overnight marches in heavy rain on minimal rations, many soldiers simply gave up the march, lying by the roadside until picked up by pursuing forces.

For two more days, Lee's army trudged on until it approached the village of Appomattox Court House, 90 miles (145km) west of Richmond. Lee rallied his troops for a final effort, seeking to break through the Union forces in order to reach the Virginia and Tennessee railroad at Lynchburg. The Confederates cleared a screen of Union horsemen, only to confront two infantry corps falling into line. Other Northern troops were approaching from the rear. Lee's redoubtable Army of Northern Virginia—what was left of it—was finally trapped.

Faced with the situation he had sought to avoid, Lee called a meeting of his commanders. Fighting on, it was agreed, would be a useless sacrifice. Someone suggested letting the men slip away into the countryside to fight as guerrillas, but Lee rejected the proposal. To do so, he said, would inflict destruction on regions that might otherwise have escaped it. "We would bring on a state of affairs it would take the country years to recover from," he concluded.

That left only one course of action. Grant had already put out peace feelers a couple of days earlier, but Lee had sent a temporizing response. Now with a heavy heart, he dispatched a message to his opponent; he was ready to discuss "the surrender of this army."